Partner Emotion Regulation: Before and During COVID

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INTRODUCTION

Existing research has shown that individuals effectively regulate their own emotions, but few studies have explored how relationship partners use a variety of strategies to regulate our emotions.

We investigated the effectiveness of partner emotion regulation (ER) from the perspective of targets (i.e., the partner experiencing the emotion) and regulators (i.e., the partner regulating the target's emotions) before and during COVID.

METHOD

Participants: 197 cohabitating couples recruited from ResearchMatch and UR CTSI completed a 14-day daily diary.

Daily Measures

Partner ER (as regulators)

- Reported use of positive and negative ER strategies: e.g., I suggested that my partner try not to express their negative emotions.
- Today, how effective were you in changing your partner's positive/negative emotions?

Partner ER (as targets)

- Perceived use of positive and negative ER strategies: e.g., My partner suggested that I try not to express my negative emotions.
- Today, how effective was your partner in influence your positive/negative emotions?

Data collection began before the COVID-19 stay-at-home restrictions were in place (i.e., 12/19/19 – 3/15/20) and continued during the pandemic (i.e., 3/16/20 – 11/1/20). Multilevel models were analyzed within SPSS 27.0 MIXED.

People were more likely to encourage their partner to use suppression to regulate their negative emotions during COVID.

During COVID, women felt that their partners were no more effective on days when their partners used more suppression.

What strategies did people use before and during COVID?

Figure 1. Regulator-reported use of ER strategies

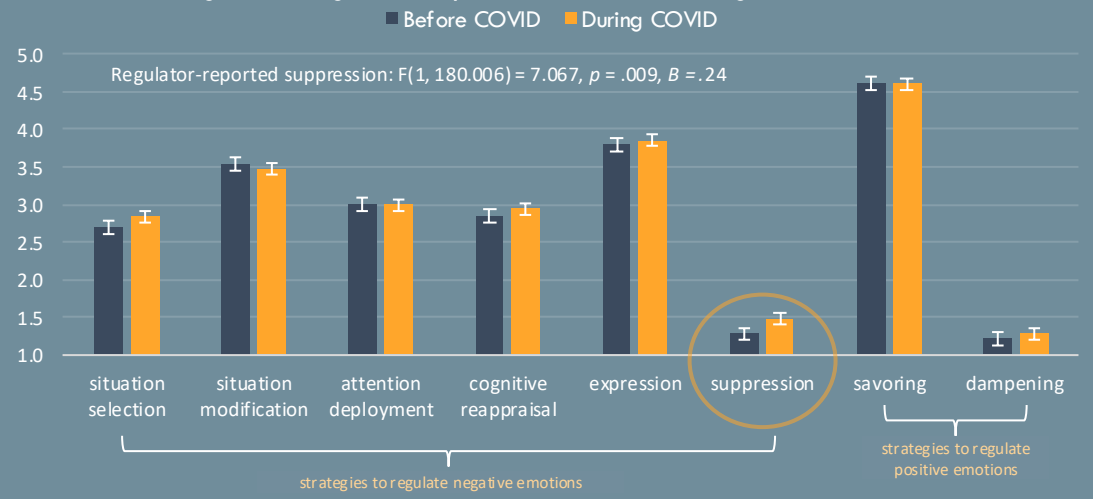

Figure 2. Target-reported partner use of ER strategies

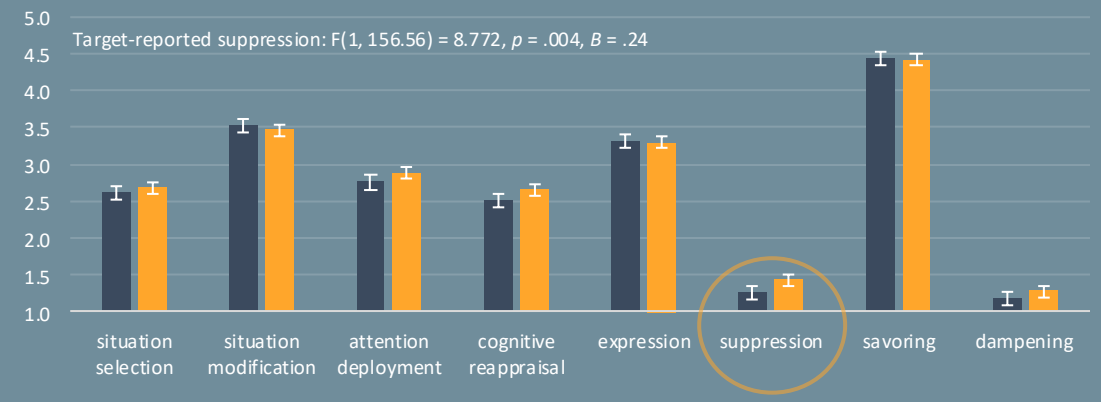

Table 1. How effective were these strategies overall?

	COVID (0 = Before, 1 = During)	*p*
regulator-reported positive ER effectiveness	F (1, 166.94) = 1.37	.244
target-reported positive ER effectiveness	F (1, 165.23) = .20	.653
regulator-reported negative ER effectiveness	F (1, 183.63) = .22	.637
target-reported negative ER effectiveness	F (1, 169.66) = 2.07	.152

Table 2. How effective was suppression? * $p < .001$

Rated effectiveness of suppression (within-person)	*Interaction p*	**Before COVID** *B (SE)*	**During COVID** *B (SE)*
female x regulator-reported suppression x COVID	.170	-.06 (.10)	.13 (.06)
female x target-reported suppression x COVID	.001	.48* (.11)	.05 (.06)
male x regulator-reported suppression x COVID	.526	.02 (.07)	-.03 (.05)
male x target-reported suppression x COVID	.383	.07 (.07)	.15 (.06)

DISCUSSION

Overall, regulators and targets felt that their positive and negative ER efforts during COVID were as effective as they were before COVID. (Table 1)

Usage of suppression: Regulators reported using more suppression to regulate their partner's negative emotions during COVID, and their partners also perceived more suppression. (Figure 1 & 2)

Effectiveness of suppression: Before COVID, women felt that their partners were more effective the more that they used suppression; during COVID, the extent to which partners used suppression on a given day was not associated with women's ratings of the partner's effectiveness. (Table 2)

This extends upon research that has shown that suppression can be used strategically to regulate one's own emotions. These findings suggest that suppression in certain contexts, may also be useful in regulating the emotions of others.